

The Masque of the Red Death

Edgar Allan Poe · 1842

First published: Graham's Magazine, May 1842

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Works_of_the_Late_Edgar_Allan_Poe_(1850)/Volume_1/The_Masque_of_the_Red_Death (revision 14967671), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 8–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Masque of the Red Death suggest about the inevitability of death?
- What does The Masque of the Red Death suggest about privilege and isolation?
- What does The Masque of the Red Death suggest about time?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	The Masque of the Red Death	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*the inevitability of death* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: The Masque of the Red Death

Focus: the futile attempt to shut out death

Content note (plague deaths): Sensitive content: Plague deaths. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes plague deaths.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

While a plague called the Red Death kills a third of his realm, Prince Prospero walls himself and a thousand nobles inside a fortified abbey. He throws a masked ball in seven colored rooms running east to west, the last black with blood-red windows and a great ebony clock. At midnight a guest disguised as a Red Death corpse appears; Prospero chases him into the black room and dies, and the revelers find the costume empty. The Red Death has entered, and all die.

Background: Poe wrote it in 1842, in a century of cholera epidemics; his wife Virginia was showing signs of tuberculosis that year.

Significance: It is read as an allegory: the rooms as stages of life, the clock as time, the stranger as death no wealth can bar.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: Why do people sometimes try to ignore a danger instead of facing it? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes plague deaths.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are bedewed, dabbled, bizarre, seizure, maddening. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "And one by one dropped the revellers in the blood-bedewed halls of their revel, and died each in the despairing posture of his fall." In this sentence it means: wet with drops, as of dew or tears. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of The Masque of the Red Death would have known. Poe wrote it in 1842, in a century of cholera epidemics; his wife Virginia was showing signs of tuberculosis that year. Why does this story matter? It is read as an allegory: the rooms as stages of life, the clock as time, the stranger as death no wealth can bar. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for symbolism.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "The "Red Death"" I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to the futile attempt to shut out death? I circle "seizure", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find symbolism, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for symbolism.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of symbolism. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *The "Red Death" had long devastated the country. No pestilence had ever been so fatal, or so hideous. Blood was its Avator and its seal—the redness and the horror of blood. There were sharp pains, and sudden dizziness, and then profuse bleeding at the pores, with dissolution. The scarlet stains upon the body and especially upon the face of the victim, were the pest ban which shut him out from the aid and from the sympathy of his fellow-men. And the whole seizure, progress and termination of the disease, were the incidents of half an hour.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Symbolism, Setting, Imagery: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how The Masque of the Red Death develops the idea of the futile attempt to shut out death. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of symbolism and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to the inevitability of death? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about the futile attempt to shut out death, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how symbolism shapes the futile attempt to shut out death. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
bedewed (verb)	wet with drops, as of dew or tears	*And one by one dropped the revellers in the blood-bedewed halls of their revel, and died each in the despairing posture of his fall.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
dabbled (verb)	dip a foot or hand briefly into a liquid	*His vesture was dabbled in blood—and his broad brow, with all the features of the face, was besprinkled with the scarlet horror.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
bizarre (adjective)	conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual	*Here the case was very different; as might have been expected from the duke's love of the bizarre.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
seizure (noun)	capture; being taken by force	*And the whole seizure, progress and termination of the disease, were the incidents of half an hour.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
maddening (adjective)	driving one wild	*It was then, however, that the Prince Prospero, maddening with rage and the shame of his own momentary cowardice, rushed hurriedly through the six chambers, while none followed him on account of a deadly terror that had seized upon all.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
profuse (adjective)	produced or growing in extreme abundance	*There were sharp pains, and sudden dizziness, and then profuse bleeding at the pores, with dissolution.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
windings (noun)	the act of winding or twisting	*To the right and left, in the middle of each wall, a tall and narrow Gothic window looked out upon a closed corridor which pursued the windings of the suite.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
quieted (verb)	calmed	*And then the music ceased, as I have told; and the evolutions of the waltzers were quieted; and there was an uneasy cessation of all things as before.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

cessation (noun)	a stopping	*And then the music ceased, as I have told; and the evolutions of the waltzers were quieted; and there was an uneasy cessation of all things as before.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
decorum (noun)	propriety in manners and conduct	*In truth the masquerade license of the night was nearly unlimited; but the figure in question had out-Heroded Herod, and gone beyond the bounds of even the prince's indefinite decorum.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Why do people sometimes try to ignore a danger instead of facing it?
2. Where does symbolism appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with the inevitability of death?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Prince Prospero do when the plague strikes? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: He shuts himself and a thousand nobles in an abbey
2. How many rooms are in the imperial suite? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Seven
3. What object in the black room makes the dancers pause each hour? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A gigantic ebony clock
4. How is the mysterious guest disguised? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: As a corpse marked by the Red Death
5. What do the revelers find when they seize the stranger? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: The mask and shroud are empty
6. Retell the three most important events of "The Masque of the Red Death" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: While a plague called the Red Death kills a third of his realm, Prince Prospero walls himself and a thousand nobles inside a fortified abbey. He throws a masked ball in seven colored rooms running east to west, the last black with blood-red windows and a great ebony clock. At midnight a guest disguised as a Red Death corpse appears; Prospero chases him into the black room and dies, and the…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "The Masque of the Red Death"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "The Masque of the Red Death" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.

9. Reread: “And one by one dropped the revellers in the blood-bedewed halls of their revel, and died each in the despairing posture of his fall.” What does “bedewed” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: bedewed: wet with drops, as of dew or tears.
10. Reread: “His vesture was dabbled in blood—and his broad brow, with all the features of the face, was besprinkled with the scarlet horror.” What does “dabbled” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: dabbled: dip a foot or hand briefly into a liquid.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Masque of the Red Death” suggest about the futile attempt to shut out death? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: It is read as an allegory: the rooms as stages of life, the clock as time, the stranger as death no wealth can bar.
2. Find one example of symbolism in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.
3. How does the setting in this story shape what we understand about the futile attempt to shut out death? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.
4. In the passage that begins “The “Red Death””, why might Poe have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Masque of the Red Death”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: While a plague called the Red Death kills a third of his realm, Prince Prospero walls himself and a thousand nobles inside a fortified abbey. He throws a masked ball in seven colored rooms running east to west, the last black with blood-red windows and a great ebony clock. At midnight a guest…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Masque of the Red Death” set up that the rest of The Masque of the Red Death will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “Why do people sometimes try to ignore a danger instead of facing it?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does imagery appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with the inevitability of death? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create.
10. Background: Poe wrote it in 1842, in a century of cholera epidemics; his wife Virginia was showing signs of tuberculosis that year. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: "It is read as an allegory: the rooms as stages of life, the clock as time, the stranger as death no wealth can bar." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of "The Masque of the Red Death" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about the futile attempt to shut out death? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about "The Masque of the Red Death": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to privilege and isolation: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Poe need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the symbolism in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how "The Masque of the Red Death" treats the futile attempt to shut out death with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Masque of the Red Death see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve the inevitability of death? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the futile attempt to shut out death? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Edgar Allan Poe about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Symbolism:** look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Setting**: where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling
- Also notice **Imagery**: sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create

Chapter quiz

1. What does Prince Prospero do when the plague strikes?
   A. He shuts himself and a thousand nobles in an abbey
   B. He burns the villages
   C. He flees to another country
   D. He nurses the sick
2. How many rooms are in the imperial suite?
   A. Twelve
   B. Seven
   C. Three
   D. One
3. What object in the black room makes the dancers pause each hour?
   A. A fountain
   B. A bell tower
   C. A gigantic ebony clock
   D. An organ
4. How is the mysterious guest disguised?
   A. As a monk
   B. As the prince
   C. As a jester
   D. As a corpse marked by the Red Death
5. What do the revelers find when they seize the stranger?
   A. He is the prince's brother
   B. The mask and shroud are empty
   C. He is a thief
   D. He is a doctor
6. In the line “And one by one dropped the revellers in the blood-bedewed halls of their revel, and died each in the despairing posture of his fall.”, what does “bedewed” most nearly mean?
   A. wet with drops, as of dew or tears
   B. dip a foot or hand briefly into a liquid
   C. capture; being taken by force
   D. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual
7. In the line “His vesture was dabbled in blood—and his broad brow, with all the features of the face, was besprinkled with the scarlet horror.”, what does “dabbled” most nearly mean?
   A. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual
   B. dip a foot or hand briefly into a liquid
   C. wet with drops, as of dew or tears
   D. capture; being taken by force

Answer key: 1. A (He shuts himself and a thousand nobles in an abbey); 2. B (Seven); 3. C (A gigantic ebony clock); 4. D (As a corpse marked by the Red Death); 5. B (The mask and shroud are empty); 6. A (wet with drops, as of dew or tears); 7. B (dip a foot or hand briefly into a liquid)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.4, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.12, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In "The Masque of the Red Death," how does Poe show the futile attempt to shut out death? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the symbolism you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1): In The Masque of the Red Death, how does Poe develop the idea of the futile attempt to shut out death? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the symbolism in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how The Masque of the Red Death develops the idea of the futile attempt to shut out death. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of symbolism and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of The Masque of the Red Death (where it begins, turns and ends) and its symbolism shape the reader's understanding of the futile attempt to shut out death. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what The Masque of the Red Death suggests about the futile attempt to shut out death. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's symbolism and setting), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Edgar Allan Poe uses symbolism in The Masque of the Red Death to complicate the reader's understanding of the futile attempt to shut out death. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Masque of the Red Death within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of the futile attempt to shut out death responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Masque of the Red Death alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of the futile attempt to shut out death follows or bends those conventions, using the symbolism as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Masque of the Red Death and its treatment of the futile attempt to shut out death. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's symbolism and setting, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Masque of the Red Death as evidence for a larger claim about the futile attempt to shut out death in The Masque of the Red Death. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Masque of the Red Death as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of the futile attempt to shut out death. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Masque of the Red Death.

SAT-style questions

1. *Here the case was very different; as might have been expected from the duke's love of the bizarre.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “bizarre” most nearly mean?

   A. a stopping

   B. propriety in manners and conduct

   C. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual

   D. calmed

2. *The “Red Death” had long devastated the country. No pestilence had ever been so fatal, or so hideous. Blood was its Avator and its seal—the redness and the horror of blood. There were sharp pains, and sudden dizziness, and then profuse bleeding at the pores, with dissolution. The scarlet stains upon the body and especially upon the face of the victim, were the pest ban which shut him out from the aid and from the sympathy of his fellow-men. And the whole seizure, progress and termination of the disease, were the incidents of half an hour.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Masque of the Red Death”?

   A. Superstition used against a credulous man

   B. The arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently

   C. The foolishness of wishing to be young again

   D. The futile attempt to shut out death

SAT key: 1. C (conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual); 2. D (The futile attempt to shut out death)

Whole-book test

The Masque of the Red Death: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. What does Prince Prospero do when the plague strikes?
   A. He shuts himself and a thousand nobles in an abbey
   B. He burns the villages
   C. He flees to another country
   D. He nurses the sick
2. How many rooms are in the imperial suite?
   A. Twelve
   B. Seven
   C. Three
   D. One
3. What object in the black room makes the dancers pause each hour?
   A. A fountain
   B. A bell tower
   C. A gigantic ebony clock
   D. An organ
4. How is the mysterious guest disguised?
   A. As a monk
   B. As the prince
   C. As a jester
   D. As a corpse marked by the Red Death
5. What do the revelers find when they seize the stranger?
   A. He is the prince's brother
   B. The mask and shroud are empty
   C. He is a thief
   D. He is a doctor
6. In the line “And one by one dropped the revellers in the blood-bedewed halls of their revel, and died each in the despairing posture of his fall.”, what does “bedewed” most nearly mean?
   A. wet with drops, as of dew or tears
   B. dip a foot or hand briefly into a liquid
   C. capture; being taken by force
   D. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual

7. In the line “His vesture was dabbled in blood—and his broad brow, with all the features of the face, was besprinkled with the scarlet horror.”, what does “dabbled” most nearly mean?
   A. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual
   B. dip a foot or hand briefly into a liquid
   C. wet with drops, as of dew or tears
   D. capture; being taken by force
8. As used in the story (“And one by one dropped the revellers in the blood-bedewed halls of their revel, and died each in the despairing posture of his fall.”), what does “bedewed” mean?
   A. wet with drops, as of dew or tears
   B. driving one wild
   C. calmed
   D. dip a foot or hand briefly into a liquid
9. As used in the story (“His vesture was dabbled in blood—and his broad brow, with all the features of the face, was besprinkled with the scarlet horror.”), what does “dabbled” mean?
   A. produced or growing in extreme abundance
   B. dip a foot or hand briefly into a liquid
   C. a stopping
   D. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual
10. As used in the story (“Here the case was very different; as might have been expected from the duke's love of the bizarre.”), what does “bizarre” mean?
    A. the act of winding or twisting
    B. propriety in manners and conduct
    C. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual
    D. capture; being taken by force
11. As used in the story (“And the whole seizure, progress and termination of the disease, were the incidents of half an hour.”), what does “seizure” mean?
    A. calmed
    B. wet with drops, as of dew or tears
    C. driving one wild
    D. capture; being taken by force
12. As used in the story (“It was then, however, that the Prince Prospero, maddening with rage and the shame of his own momentary cowardice, rushed hurriedly through t”), what does “maddening” mean?
    A. driving one wild
    B. a stopping
    C. dip a foot or hand briefly into a liquid
    D. produced or growing in extreme abundance

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how the inevitability of death develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how privilege and isolation develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how time develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (the inevitability of death, privilege and isolation, time) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. A (He shuts himself and a thousand nobles in an abbey); 2. B (Seven); 3. C (A gigantic ebony clock); 4. D (As a corpse marked by the Red Death); 5. B (The mask and shroud are empty); 6. A (wet with drops, as of dew or tears); 7. B (dip a foot or hand briefly into a liquid); 8. A (wet with drops, as of dew or tears); 9. B (dip a foot or hand briefly into a liquid); 10. C (conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual); 11. D (capture; being taken by force); 12. A (driving one wild)

Essay assignments

Essay: The inevitability of death

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Masque of the Red Death teaches about the inevitability of death. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops the inevitability of death in The Masque of the Red Death. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops the inevitability of death across The Masque of the Red Death. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Masque of the Red Death (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of the inevitability of death. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of the inevitability of death in The Masque of the Red Death. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Masque of the Red Death (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of the inevitability of death, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Masque of the Red Death's treatment of the inevitability of death in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on the inevitability of death in The Masque of the Red Death that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on the inevitability of death in The Masque of the Red Death. Name

your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about the inevitability of death in The Masque of the Red Death, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on the inevitability of death in The Masque of the Red Death, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Privilege and isolation

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Masque of the Red Death teaches about privilege and isolation. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops privilege and isolation in The Masque of the Red Death. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops privilege and isolation across The Masque of the Red Death. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Masque of the Red Death (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of privilege and isolation. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of privilege and isolation in The Masque of the Red Death. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Masque of the Red Death (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of privilege and isolation, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Masque of the Red Death's treatment of privilege and isolation in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on privilege and isolation in The Masque of the Red Death that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on privilege and isolation in The Masque of the Red Death. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about privilege and isolation in The Masque of the Red Death, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on privilege and isolation in The Masque of the Red Death, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Time

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Masque of the Red Death teaches about time. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops time in The Masque of the Red Death. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops time across The Masque of the Red Death. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Masque of the Red Death (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of time. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of time in The Masque of the Red Death. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Masque of the Red Death (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of time, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Masque of the Red Death's treatment of time in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on time in The Masque of the Red Death that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on time in The Masque of the Red Death. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about time in The Masque of the Red Death, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on time in The Masque of the Red Death, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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